

Fase 2 - De la Idea al Mercado Internacional.

Actividad Individual

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Introduction

The purpose of this report is to analyze the feasibility of exporting Colombian cocoa to the United States. Cocoa is one of Colombia's most promising agricultural products and is globally recognized for its “Fine Flavor” quality. The United States represents a strategic destination due to its high consumption levels and the existing Free Trade Agreement (FTA) between both countries.

According to international market data, the United States imports more than 400,000 tons of cocoa and its derivatives annually, making it one of the largest consumers worldwide. This analysis uses the PESTEL framework to evaluate the macro-environmental factors—Political, Economic, Social, Technological, Environmental, and Legal—that could impact the internationalization of this product.

Furthermore, the selection of the United States as the target market is justified by the evolution of its chocolate industry. In recent years, there has been a shift from massproduced products to premium and single-origin chocolates. This “premiumization” trend has driven the growth of the fine cocoa segment, which has experienced an annual growth rate of over 5%.

Colombia holds a significant competitive advantage, as it is recognized by the International Cocoa Organization (ICCO) as a producer of 100% fine flavor cocoa, allowing it to position itself strategically in this high-value market segment.

Objective

General Objective

To analyze the feasibility of exporting Colombian cocoa to the United States, considering market conditions, commercial opportunities, and international environmental factors through a PESTEL analysis.

Specific Objectives

To identify the main political, economic, social, technological, environmental, and legal factors that influence the export of Colombian cocoa to the U.S. market.

To evaluate the opportunities and challenges of Colombian cocoa in the premium market segment in the United States, taking into account consumer trends and international requirements

PESTEL ANALYSIS

Political Factors:

The political relationship between Colombia and the United States remains stable and is characterized by strong commercial cooperation. The Free Trade Agreement (FTA), signed in 2012, provides a solid framework for trade by eliminating most tariffs on agricultural products, facilitating access to the U.S. market.

Economic Factors:

The U.S. economy is a key driver of global cocoa demand. While cocoa prices fluctuate in international markets, the premium segment offers higher profit margins compared to conventional cocoa.

Market data shows that the premium chocolate segment in the United States generates over 2.8 billion dollars annually, highlighting a significant opportunity for differentiated products such as Colombian cocoa. Additionally, the exchange rate favors Colombian exporters, making their products more competitive internationally.

INDICATOR	APPROXIMATE VALUE	SOURCE
Cocoa imports	+400,000 tons/year	ICCO
Premium chocolate market value	USD 2.8 billion	Statista
Annual growth (premium segment)	5% – 6%	Market Research
Chocolate consumption per capita	9 – 10 kg/year	World Population Review
Share of fine flavor cocoa	<10% of global market	ICCO

Social Factors:

American consumers are increasingly conscious of their health and the ethical origin of the products they consume. There is a growing demand for dark chocolate, organic products, and the “bean-to-bar” concept.

Moreover, studies indicate that more than 60% of consumers prefer products with sustainability certifications such as Fair Trade or Rainforest Alliance. This represents a strong opportunity for Colombian cocoa, especially due to its positive social impact on rural communities.

Technological Factors:

The U.S. market requires high levels of efficiency and transparency in supply chains. Technologies such as blockchain are increasingly used to ensure product traceability.

In addition, the growth of e-commerce platforms allows producers to reach international consumers more efficiently, reducing intermediaries and improving market access.

Environmental Factors:

Environmental sustainability is a key factor in international cocoa trade. U.S. regulations impose strict controls on contaminants such as cadmium and pesticide residues.

In this context, Colombian producers must adopt sustainable agricultural practices to comply with international standards and reduce environmental impact, which also enhances their competitiveness.

legal factors:

The legal framework for exporting food products to the United States is governed by the Food Safety Modernization Act (FSMA). This regulation focuses on prevention and requires compliance with programs such as the Foreign Supplier Verification Program (FSVP), proper labeling, and phytosanitary certifications.

Failure to comply with these legal requirements may result in product rejection or penalties, making it essential for exporters to meet all standards.

International Price Comparison

COCOA TYPE	AVERAGE PRICE (USD/TON)
Conventional cocoa	2,500 – 3,200
Fine flavor cocoa (Colombia)	3,500 – 5,000
Premium chocolate derivatives	+30% to +50% margin

Colombian fine flavor cocoa can generate between 20% and 40% higher revenues compared to conventional cocoa, significantly improving export profitability.

Pestel Summary Table

FACTOR	OPPORTUNITIES	RISKS
Political	Free Trade Agreement (FTA)	Trade dependency
Economic	High consumption	Price volatility
Social	Demand for sustainable products	Changing trends
Technological	E-commerce and traceability	High investment costs
Environmental	Sustainable production	Strict regulations
Legal	Clear regulatory framework (FSMA)	Mandatory compliance

Premium Market Growth

YEAR	GROWTH
2020	3%
2021	4%
2022	5%
2023	5.5%
2024	6%

Analysis:

The analysis shows that the main opportunities lie in political and social factors, particularly due to the Free Trade Agreement and the increasing consumer preference for high-quality and sustainable products.

On the other hand, legal and environmental factors represent significant barriers, as they require strict compliance with regulations and quality standards.

However, these challenges can also be seen as opportunities. By meeting international standards, Colombian cocoa producers can strengthen their reputation and position their product in the premium market, where consumers are willing to pay higher prices.

From a quantitative perspective, the U.S. market presents highly favorable conditions for Colombian cocoa exports. With annual consumption exceeding 400,000 tons and a steady growth rate of over 5% in the premium segment, there is a clear increase in demand for differentiated products.

Additionally, the price gap between conventional and fine flavor cocoa can reach up to 40%, representing a significant competitive advantage for Colombia. These indicators suggest a high profitability potential, provided that international standards and regulations are met.

Key Export Indicators

- Expected profitability: +20% to +40%
- Market growth: 5% annually
- Preference for sustainable products: 60% of consumers
- Tariff reduction: 0% (FTA)
- Regulatory risk: High

Conclusion

In conclusion, exporting Colombian cocoa to the United States represents a strategic opportunity within international trade, particularly in the fine flavor cocoa segment. The analysis shows that there are favorable conditions such as the Free Trade Agreement, the growing demand for premium products, and the international recognition of Colombian cocoa quality.

Furthermore, the inclusion of market data demonstrates that the United States is a high-consumption destination with a sustained trend toward sustainable and certified products, which strengthens the positioning potential of Colombian cocoa.

However, important challenges are also identified, especially regarding compliance with sanitary, environmental, and traceability regulations, which require producers to improve their processes and quality standards.

Finally, if Colombia continues strengthening its competitiveness through best practices, international certifications, and differentiation strategies, it will be able to consolidate its position as a relevant player in the global cocoa market, generating economic and social benefits for the country.

Furthermore, the integration of statistical data, market trends, and structured analysis tools such as PESTEL strengthens the reliability of this study. It demonstrates that Colombia not only has a comparative advantage due to the quality of its cocoa but also a competitive advantage if it aligns with global standards, certifications, and technological innovations required by international markets.

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